

## Socratic Ideals and the Complexities of Justice

Justice is at the heart of Plato's Republic. In this philosophical dialogue, Socrates embarks on a journey to uncover its true nature by inviting us to reconsider our understanding of fundamental ethical principles. To do so Socrates critiques various definitions of justice proposed by his interlocutors but appears dissatisfied by the end of the last book, concluding that none of these definitions have successfully unraveled the enigma of justice (Methuen 1906, 235). However, the question remains: did Socrates truly exhaust the search for justice, or did he overlook critical aspects that define its essence?

This paper will argue that Socrates' exploration of justice in the city of speech and the soul is undermined by some of his assumptions. I will support this argument by bringing to attention the disanalogy of the city and soul, the importance of virtues and that of equality over stability.

Throughout this paper I will first carefully examine the distinctions between justice in the soul and in the city, then the debate surrounding the natural and conventional aspects of justice, and thirdly Socrates' vision of an ideal city of wisdom. This exploration of the Republic's themes will intend to shed light on the multifaceted nature of justice, providing a more nuanced understanding of this concept that continues to be a subject of philosophical inquiry.

First of all, aspects of justice in the city and in the soul create a disanalogy between the two. In Plato's Republic, Socrates extensively defines visions of justice to confront them. Nevertheless, before doing so he sets up a number of definitions by establishing central notions to his argument: minding one's own business being one of them. In book 5 of the Republic, it means being self-sufficient (Methuen 1906, 96), yet in the previous book, the same idea is used in a different context: it now calls for doing what you have predispositions for and being dependent on others for things you are not suited for yourself. If it seems strange to have opposing explanations for this idea, a third one gives a more universal answer to the problematic: minding one's own business is doing whatever one can do to be the best human being possible (Methuen 1906, 90). That seems to contradict Socrates' other monoliths: the city in speech and the soul. The first is a process of ideas shared between Socrates and his peers in the form of debates to determine what an ideal city would look like. The latter is compared to the city, as Socrates deems that both follow a similar structure: they are ruled by virtues that depend on different parts: a calculating part, an honor loving one and an appetitive one. The issue with this analogy is that Socrates indicates that justice in the city is when one minds his own business. Therefore, in the soul, as each part can only do its own business, does it mean that a soul is always just? Besides, doesn't the pursuit of bettering yourself entail that the soul is not perfect as otherwise it would already predispose all humans to justice?

Plato does in fact address similar concerns by explaining that justice in the soul is closer to moderation in the city: it should be seen as a form of self-mastery and control (Lecture 6). Nevertheless, this explanation does not reduce my doubts; why would there be a need for restraint in a perfect city and what does that say about the importance of freedom in Socrates' perception of perfection?

Secondly, the premises Socrates works with to establish his city in speech might be what prevents him from finding true justice. Indeed, to ensure that the population of the city, especially the guardian class, acts as Socrates intends and doesn't disrupt the balance of power, a noble lie is put in place (Methuen 1906, 43). This invented religion explains the origins of the city and why everyone should follow its teachings. However, Socrates, in using this, shapes a society in which institutions and minds are focused on what Socrates finds the most important: the four cardinal virtues and among them especially wisdom and justice. All the more, he calls just those who employ their efforts and might to pursue these virtues, which here are almost like the only accepted goals: "That rule which we at first established, when we regulated the city, as what ought always to be done, that, as it appears to me, or a species of it, is justice"(Methuen 1906, 88). I would tend to find more virtue in an individual who is critical of his environment and can make assessments for themselves to the typical guardian in the city of speech who readily abandons all other aspirations than his quest for wisdom, even if he thinks it is for the good of the city. In the end, what I find most bothersome is the idea that justice can prevail in a world of lies: Socrates seems to choose stability and predictability over exposing the truth, as if burned by the scorching sun outside the Cave, never to leave its darkness again.

In the same manner, another assumption of Socrates leads me to believe the justice he is seeking comes at the price of other principles.

Finally, shaping a city like shaping a soul doesn't work: justice, as Socrates asserts, is fundamentally about equality among individuals, yet when we examine the structure of his ideal city in the Republic, we find a stark contradiction. Socrates separates the population into distinct classes and assigns them roles based on their innate abilities, effectively discriminating between citizens and creating a meritocracy. Nonetheless, he justifies this by arguing that finding

fulfillment in one's designated position will bring about justice (Methuen 1906, 96). Indeed, by following our "logismos": a part of the soul acting as the calculating and wise part, Socrates suggests that what is best for each individual is the key to justice. However, this only seems to perpetuate a system that presupposes justice through conservation of balance rather than promoting equality. This leads to a tension between individual pursuits and societal definitions of justice, raising questions about whether the city and the soul can be closely related. In essence, Socrates' attempt to shape both exposes a profound disparity in his vision of justice, highlighting the complexities and ambiguities within this central philosophical concept.

In conclusion, this paper has argued that Socrates' exploration of justice in both the city of speech and the soul is undermined by certain assumptions. Socrates' vision of justice in the city, as a well-structured hierarchy with roles defined by innate abilities, contradicts his vision of justice in the soul, which is based on individual fulfillment. While he emphasizes the importance of each individual's "logismos" in pursuing their best course, this may inadvertently perpetuate a system that favors stability over equality. Socrates' inclination towards predictability and control, as evident in the use of the noble lie to shape society, highlights a tension between individual aspirations and societal definitions of justice. In essence, Socrates' quest for justice in both the city and the soul reveals a profound disparity within his philosophical vision, emphasizing the intricate and multifaceted nature of the concept.

Bibliography :

Plato. "The Republic." Translated by Methuen and Co, Methuen's Standard Library, 1906.

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